

THE KNAVE'S REGRET

A Vhasian Expansion for Fate's Edge

Set down in the canton of Rouen, by the Silent Stair

“When the armor closes, the heart must open—or break.”

Under the lamp, bread and salt — and a song for the armor-bound.

Year of the Broken Lance, 847 AR

For the knight who unbuckled his gorget to hear a boy's voice.
For the Cantor who carries the silence between notes.
For the chivalry that outlives the peace.

The Cantor's Vigil

THE bells of Rouen ring differently now. In the cantons beyond the walls—where the ducal forests meet the Ethorian marches—they ring for jousts and for the binding of seasonal oaths. Within the city they ring for markets and marriages. In the Chapel of the Silent Stair, however, the bells are muffled, wrapped in felt so that their resonance does not disturb the dead.

Alain has returned to Vhasia after twenty years on the Cantor's road. He has sung for barons in drafty halls and for charcoal-burners in smoke-filled hollows. He bears the Corruption of his patron—not as a curse, but as a translation. His voice now carries harmonics that make candles weep wax; his shadow, when the sun is low, moves a half-step behind his heels. Fine feathers—down-soft as a newborn's—grow from his temples, hidden beneath a scholar's cap.

He presses the ring on his thumb. It is no longer pure silver but silver fused to bone, a crack widened by time into a canyon that pulses with his heartbeat. Tonight he will sing the *Planctus Armatus*, the Lament for the Armored—a Cantor's rite that remembers Sir Corin, the knight who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief's voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.

The song is not for the knight's death. It is for the moment before—when the armor opens and the man inside reaches out.

The Province Wars had not yet ended when Sir Corin found the boy. The great cantons of Vhasia were fracturing along

ancient fault-lines: Ethor against Adria, the Ethorian marches against the central cantons, each duke claiming the sunburst seal while the peasantry burned the fields to keep armies from quartering there. Rouen was a loyalist city then, holding for the Crown while the provinces fell away like scales from a wounded serpent.

Corin had ridden from the rout at Black Ford, where the Bulwark of the North fell not to treachery but to arithmetic—too many spears, not enough stone. He rode through an ash-grey morning, his armor still caked with the ford's mud, his sword hand cramped from gripping the hilt. He was forty, a knight of the Ethor canton, sworn to a Crown that had long forgotten his name.

He found the boy in a burned orchard, looting the corpse of a cook. The boy was twelve, humming a tuneless fragment as he worked the dead man's ring free from his thumb. The kitchen still smelled of fresh dough and smoke; a sack of flour lay open beside the body, a reminder of the night the cook had been forced to feed a starving garrison.

"Stand," Corin ordered.

The boy stood. The ring slipped free. Corin saw the theft and, behind it, the hunger. The wars had made thieves of honest men, but this was a child.

"I should hang you," Corin said. He meant it. He had hanged men for less—deserters, looters, those who broke the chivalric code that was the only law left in the fractured duchies.

Instead of pleading, the boy began to sing. It was not a song of fear but a simple, halting lament he had learned while kneading bread for the cook. The rhythm staggered like a limping man, the melody rising and falling like dough in a hearth. He sang the "Old Vhasian Ballad" that would later echo in Alain's

own voice.

*"Forget-me-not,"
The proud knight said,
Dressed and ready for war.
His lady kissed him through her tears,
Fearing to see him no more.

Down by the river, where the purple flowers grow,
He held her close and whispered his love,
But armed and armored, he felt not her touch—
The silk of her delicate glove.

She wept. He rose, as if to leave,
But turned for the flowers instead.
Overreaching, he tumbled down,
And as he sank, he said,
"Forget-me-not."*

Corin listened. His armor was heavy. It had been heavy for twenty years, but he had stopped noticing its weight until this moment, until this clumsy, heartfelt thing rose from a soot-streaked child. He realized he had not seen his own face in a mirror unhelmed for months; he realized he could no longer picture his wife's eyes, only the shape of her letters, read by lantern-light through his visor.

"Who taught you that?" Corin asked, his voice softer now, the edge of the hanging judge gone from it.

"The cook," the boy said, gesturing to the dead man. "He was kind. He taught me to knead, and he taught me the song. Said it was about the weight of things we choose to carry."

Corin loosened the twine that bound the boy's wrist. Not enough to free him, but enough to let the blood flow. "Walk,"

he said. "And sing if you must. The road to Rouen is long, and the armor grows heavier with every mile."

Rouen was a city of bells and fractures. The loyalist governor held the citadel, but the lower town was a maze of competing jurisdictions—ducal law, canton law, the law of the sword. Corin brought the boy to the empty courthouse, intending to fulfil his oath of justice, but the magistrate had fled to Adria, and the seals were broken.

The boy watched Corin's face crumble. "There is no law," he said. "Only the armor. Only the song."

Corin drew his dagger. The boy did not flinch. Cutting the twine, Corin unbuckled something inside himself. He had kept the chivalric code like a gorget, tight against his throat; now he loosened it to breathe.

"Stay," Corin said. "Help me hold the walls. Help me remember what the armor is for."

The boy stayed. His name was Alain. He carried water. He sang.

The siege pressed on for a week, a relentless tide of iron and fire that rolled against Rouen's ancient walls. The provincial army, angry that the loyalist banner still flew over the citadel, resolved to raze the city as a warning to the rest of the cantons. Battering rams knelled the outer gate while torch-lit ranks surged forward, their shadows dancing like black-winged swallows on the cobblestones.

Corin was at the heart of the defence. From the south

gate he barked orders that cut through the clamor like a sword through wheat, his voice a low, steady drum that steadied the weary militia. He dispatched archers to the parapets, shored up the wooden palisades, and slipped a hand-signed letter to the quartermaster demanding more supplies. Alain watched him only in passing—an outline of steel beneath a cracked helm, a flash of determined eyes that never lingered long enough for a name to settle on his tongue. The knight's presence was felt more than seen; it was the clink of gauntlets, the rustle of a cloak, the unspoken promise that the gate would hold—at least for a while.

When the first wave of fire-spitting siege engines hurled burning projectiles into the city, Alain felt the heat kiss the back of his neck. He could have fled, could have hidden behind the market stalls like the rest of the townsfolk, but the boy-song still rang in his ears and the cracked ring on his thumb pulsed with an urgency he could not ignore. He thought of the cook's flour-dusted hands, of the lullaby the child sang while kneading dough, and of the promise the song carried: *"Forget-me-not."* With that memory as his shield, he made a silent vow.

He turned away from the chaos and knelt beside a small alley where a wounded child—no older than five—lay cradled in a heap of tattered blankets. The boy's breath was shallow, his cheek stained with ash. Alain lifted him, his feathered hair brushing the child's forehead, and hurried toward the chapel, the only place that still offered shelter from the rain of arrows.

The battle raged on, and by the time the seventh day's sun rose pale over the smoke-blackened horizon, the southern gate finally gave way. The wall crumbled, and the conquering forces surged into the city's streets. In the midst of the clamor, Alain felt a hand grasp his own—strong, calloused, and surprisingly

gentle. It was Sir Corin, his armor stripped of the ornamental gilding that had once glittered in tournament light, the visor half-drawn as though he wished to see the faces of those he was fighting.

Alain saw only a fleeting glimpse: Corin's gauntlet, clenched around the child's small hand for a heartbeat, then released as the knight turned to shield the little one from a falling beam. The knight's eyes, dark as forged iron, met Alain's for a breath-long instant, and in that look an unspoken apology passed—they would not fight side-by-side, but they shared the same sorrow.

When the fighting finally ebbed, a grim procession emerged from the ruined square. Corin's body, still clad in the battered plates of his own making, was lifted upon a makeshift stretcher by two exhausted soldiers. The culminating moment was not the roar of triumph from the victors, but the cold, detached words of the conquering lady who had overseen the assault—Lady Isolde of the Western March, her sable cloak heavy with the scent of pine and iron.

She halted before the stretcher, her gloved hand resting lightly on the knight's breastplate, where the insignia of the Order of the Iron Gorget was still faintly visible beneath the scorch. Her eyes, usually sharp as a hawk's talon, were lowered, not in grief but in calculation.

“A ransom would have solved this,” Lady Isolde said, her voice flat as steel. “We could have taken a price and avoided the extra loss.”

Around her, the provincial infantry lowered their weapons; the clang of steel fell silent as the reality of the cost settled over the courtyard. Lord Merrick of the Black Vale, who had ordered

the sack, watched the scene with a slight grimace—aware that the price of victory had already been paid in blood, not gold.

Alain knelt beside the stretcher, his feathers ruffling with each gust of wind that carried ash and sorrow alike. He pressed his lips to the cold steel of Corin's breastplate and sang the opening verses of the *Planctus Armatus*, the lament that would become the very soul of the stave. His voice rose, raw and trembling, over the ruined chapel's cracked arches, and the soldiers who had come to loot paused, their swords trembling in their hands, as the song wove the image of a knight who chose mercy over steel.

When the final note fell, the chapel's roof shuddered and a fire-kissed collapse began. Flames licked the rafters, and the wind seemed to echo the boy's forgotten ballad, "Forget-me-not," as the stone walls crumbled around them.

Thus Sir Corin was carried out, his body a monument to both his courage and his vulnerability, while the conquering lord and lady stood on the threshold of the ruined chapel—recognising, in their own cold way, that even the most practiced chivalry could not mask the brutal reality of war.

Now, forty years later, Alain sings in the rebuilt chapel. The Province Wars are ended, technically, though the duchies still raid one another and the Crown is more theory than practice. Rouen is prosperous. Jousts have returned to the fields beyond the walls. Knights wear armor polished like mirrors and tilt for the favor of ladies whose names they remember, because peace allows memory.

Alain knows—knows in his altered flesh, in the feathers

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that shed when he hits the high notes, in the shadow that moves a half-step behind him when the moon is full—that the disconnect remains. Knights buckle their gorgets tight. Chivalry is performance. Mercy is scripted. Beneath the jousts and the romance, the old fractures wait, breathing in their iron shells.

He sings the *Planctus Armatus*. The congregation weeps, not for Corin—who is forty years dead—but for the beauty of the voice. They do not hear the warning. They do not know that Alain sings not for the past but for the future, for the moment when the armor must open again or shatter.

The song ends. Alain touches the cracked ring on his thumb. It pulses. The peace is old. The armor is polished. Yet beneath the prosperity he can hear the creak of metal tightening, the snap of buckles being secured, the silence of hearts choosing protection over connection.

He bows. He leaves. His shadow follows a half-step behind.

This chronicle was compiled from the Cantor's testimony, from the armorer's marks on Corin's breastplate (now in the Rouen museum), and from the Ethorian ballads of the marches, which remember what the cantons forget.

— *Dusana of the Raven Road, Rouen, 847 AR*

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Chapter 1

Game-Mechanics Overview

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first tabletop role-playing game. Every action is resolved with the same three-step loop:

1. **Declare intent & approach.** The player says what they are trying to do and which skill they are using.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV) and Position.** The GM decides how hard the task is ($DV = 2-6$) and whether the actor is in a *Dominant*, *Controlled*, or *Desperate* position. Position modifies the roll and may grant a *Boon*.
3. **Roll the dice pool.** Roll a number of d10 equal to **Attribute + Skill**. Each result of 6-10 is a success; each result of 1 generates a *Story Beat (SB)* for the GM.

The **Outcome Matrix** (see the SRD) determines what happens:

- **Clean Success** – successes $\geq DV$ and no SBs. Intent achieved, no complications.
- **Success & Cost** – successes $\geq DV$ with one or more SBs. Intent achieved, but the GM spends the SBs to add a complication, advance a clock, or worsen Position.
- **Partial** – $0 < \text{successes} < DV$. Some progress, a complication, and the player gains 1 Boon.

CHAPTER 1. GAME-MECHANICS OVERVIEW

- **Miss** – no successes. No progress, the GM spends SBs for complications, and the player gains 2 Boons.

Boons are a player-controlled resource (max 5, trimmed to 2 at the end of a scene) that can be spent to:

- Reroll one die after seeing the pool,
- Activate an asset,
- Improve Position by one step, or
- Pay for a special effect listed in a talent or rite.

Story Beats (SB) are the GM's currency for introducing complications, advancing clocks, or ticking clocks forward. Every rolled "1" creates one SB.

For a detailed description of attributes, skills, talents, clocks, and the magic system, see the attached *Fate's Edge – System Reference Document* (SRD). The rules presented here are sufficient to play the scenes in this expansion.

Chapter 2

Introduction: The Fractured Cantons

When the duke rides out, the peasant locks the door.

When the duke rides in, the peasant burns the field.

This is the chivalry of Vhasia—the armor that protects and isolates in equal measure.

— The Gray Wanderer, at the Ethorian marches

Vhasia is a land of jousts and jurisprudence, of chivalric romance and constant low war. Since the sundering of the old Crown, the great cantons have fractured into duchies, palatinates, and marcher lordships, each claiming the sunburst seal, each raiding its neighbours for tribute, hostages, and the acknowledgment of lineage.

In the high season the land is peaceful enough for tourneys. Knights polish their armor until it mirrors the sky. They ride to the tilt for the favor of ladies whose sleeves they wear, reciting verses of courtly love while the peasantry watches from the lists. Beneath the romance runs an older current: the Ethorian marches where the forest law still holds, the barrow-kings who demand tribute in stories, and the sacred groves where armor must be unbuckled or the trees will not witness the oath.

CHAPTER 2. INTRODUCTION: THE FRACTURED CANTONS

This expansion centres on the tragedy of Sir Corin and the Cantor who witnessed it, but it also expands to encompass the chivalric culture of Vhasia—the disconnect between the armored ideal and the unarmoured heart.

2.1 The Nature of Vhasian Chivalry

The knights of Vhasia follow a code older than the Crown. It demands:

- **Protection:** To defend the weak, provided they are within the knight's canton.
- **Courtesy:** To honour all ladies, provided their lineage is suitable.
- **Mercy:** To spare the defeated, provided they swear homage.

Armor is the physical manifestation of this code—interlocking plates that separate the knight from the world. To unbuckle the gorget is to risk not only death but intimacy. Corin's tragedy was that he unbuckled at the wrong moment, for the wrong mercy, and the world was not gentle enough to receive it.

2.2 What You Need

Tier: Seasoned (41–90 XP) **Players:** 3–6 **Length:** 3–4 sessions

2.2.1 Core Clocks

- **The Armor Closes [6]** — advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **The Song Escapes [8]** — advances when Cantors sing the truth, when mercy is shown, when armor is unbuckled. When full, a moment of connection occurs—though it may be fatal.
- **The Fracture Widens [10]** — advances with every chivalric gesture that masks a brutal reality. When full, the Province Wars reignite.

CHAPTER 2. INTRODUCTION: THE FRACTURED CANTONS

Chapter 3

The Cantons of Vhasia

3.1 The Ethor Canton

The loyalist heartland, where the old Crown still holds nominal sway. Its knights are stern, legalistic, devoted to the code. Corin was Ethorian. Their castles are stone, their forests hunted out, their chivalry a matter of record-keeping.

3.2 The Adria Palatinate

The south western canton, rich in wine and olive groves. Its knights are voluptuaries, lovers of poetry and song. They raid less for land than for hostages to ransom, for the drama of capture and release. Their chivalry is theatrical, performed.

3.3 The Ethorian Marches

The western forests, neighbour to Adria, where the old ways hold. Here, knights must unbuckle their armour to enter the sacred groves. The *Barde de Fer* ballads originate here, warning of the knight who forgets his humanity. The marches are Vhasia's uncivilised heart, dangerous to armoured men.

3.4 Istovar

Across the Belworth from Fenwood, Istovar is held by the Everbloods, cousins to the eponymous royal family of Viterra. Its lords are caught between two loyalties: bound by blood to the Viterran crown, yet entangled by marriage and debt to Vhasian claimants. The castle of Istovar overlooks the river's narrowest crossing, a constant irritant to both realms.

3.5 Lence

The royal seat of Vhasia, sacked by the Fenwoods and their Vhasian Everblood allies under the banner of *royal excess*. They broke the Sun Court, scattered the crown, and then—lacking the strength to hold it—left the throne empty. The crownlands were ravaged, and many barons on both sides of the Belworth have soured on the Fenwoods. Lence remains a half-ruined city, its courts silent, its bells cracked, its people waiting.

3.6 Rouen: The Hub City

Where the cantons meet and clash. Rouen is a city of inns and tourney fields, of law courts and Ethorian shrines. It is neutral ground by tradition, though neutrality is a luxury of the powerful. The Silent Stair chapel, where Alain sings, is built on the site of Sir Corin's death.

Chapter 4

Factions of the Fracture

4.1 The Order of the Iron Gorget

A knightly order sworn to the ideal of total protection. They never unbuckle, never eat without helm, never touch skin to skin. They are fearsome in battle but increasingly isolated from the people they protect. Corin was once a member; he broke his vow when he spared Alain.

Strings: The Unbroken Seal (a gorget that has never opened), the Weight of Iron (inability to feel light touch), the Ledger of Mercies Refused.

4.2 The Cantor's Road

Not a faction but a calling. Cantors travel between cantons, singing the news, bearing witness. They are immune to chivalric protection but subject to its violence. Alain is the most famous of them, the one who survived Rouen.

Strings: The Cracked Ring, the Second Voice, the Metamorphosis of Witnessing.

4.3 The Ethorian Groves

The old religion of the marches, keeper of the barrow-kings and the forest law. They demand that armor be removed on their

thresholds. They remember what the cantons forget.

Strings: The Unbuckled Threshold, the Barrow-King's Tribute (paid in stories), the Green Seal (which opens only to bare skin).

4.4 The Ducal Courts

Each canton has its court, its heralds, its keepers of chivalric record. They are the accountants of honour, tracking who owes whom the *geste* of protection.

Strings: The Sunburst Seal (fractured), the Tourney List, the Ransom Ledger.

Chapter 5

The Armor and the Song

5.1 The Ethorian Ballad of the Iron Bard

Before Corin there was the legend. The Ethorians sing of a knight so armored he forgot his own face. He rode to a grove to meet his lady, but the trees would not part for steel. He unbuckled, and in that moment of vulnerability he was struck. He died smiling, having felt the sun.

This is the paradox of Vhasian chivalry: protection requires isolation, but honour requires connection. The armor is the barrier that makes mercy possible, but it must be lowered to deliver it.

5.2 Corin's Choices

During the siege of Rouen Corin had three opportunities to re-buck his gorget:

1. When he captured Alain (he left it open to hear the song).
2. When he spared the provincial soldier (he unbuckled to offer water).
3. When he carried the child (he removed his helm to see the boy's face).

CHAPTER 5. THE ARMOR AND THE SONG

Each unbuckling was a chivalric act. Each brought him closer to the spear that would end him.

Chapter 6

Patrons of the Armoured

6.1 **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar**

Mykkiel is the patron of chivalric law, of the code that binds knights. His Vhasian face is stern: he demands that the code be followed exactly, even when it breaks the heart. Most Vhasians worship the Everflame; he is known as **Seint Michel**. Peasants pray to him for fair arbitration; knights swear oaths on his shrines before the joust.

The Oath of the Iron Fastening (Low, 4 XP)

Seal a promise in armor. It cannot be broken without physical pain. (Mark +1 Obligation.)

The Unbuckled Gorget (Standard, 8 XP)

Open your armor to show vulnerability. Gain +2 dice to mercy rolls, but -2 to defence until the gorget is closed. (Mark +2 Obligation.)

6.2 **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies**

Ikasha is the secret patron of knights who long to set aside their steel. She offers the dream of connection, the memory of skin. She is dangerous because she makes the armor feel heavy. She is known as **Seint Isabeau**.

The Forgotten Caress (Low, 4 XP)

Remember the sensation of rain on skin, of wind in hair. Gain +1 die to resist Corruption, but gain a Corruption tick anyway. (Mark +1 Fatigue.)

The Unhelmed Countenance (Standard, 8 XP)

Remove your helm in a dangerous place. You are seen truly. The enemy knows your face. (Mark +2 Corruption; gain a String on anyone who witnesses.)

6.3 **Seint Evroul of the Cairn**

Mor'iraath, the keeper of blood-debts and ancestor-witness, walks the Ethorian marches in the guise of a knight in rusted mail, his face hidden by a helm that has never been opened. He is the patron of those who carry the weight of unavenged kin, of oaths sworn on graves, of the cold duty that outlasts love. Most Vhasians fear to speak his name; in the marches, they leave a cup of salt water at the door of the crypt.

The Pledge of the Unquiet Dead (Low, 4 XP)

Swear before a witness that you will settle a wrong done to your bloodline. Until the wrong is righted, you gain +1 die to all rolls made in pursuit of that vengeance, but you mark 1 Fatigue at dawn each day you do not make progress. (Mark +1 Obligation. This Obligation cannot be cleared except by fulfilling the pledge or by a public act of renunciation that brings shame.)

The Cairn's Toll (Standard, 8 XP)

Call upon the ancestors to witness a single blow against a foe who has wronged your house. On your next melee attack, you may re-roll up to two failures. If the blow lands, the foe gains a Condition: *Marked by the Cairn* – any spirit may locate them for one year. If the blow misses, you suffer 1 Harm (the ancestors' disappointment). (Mark +2 Obligation.)

CHAPTER 6. PATRONS OF THE ARMoured

Chapter 7

The Knight's Legacy: New Talents

7.1 The Unbuckled Gorget (Minor, 4 XP)

Requirement: You have shown mercy while vulnerable.

Once per session you may declare that you remove a piece of armor (helm, gauntlet, or gorget) to show trust. Gain +1 die to social rolls with honourable enemies, but suffer +1 Harm from the next attack against you.

7.2 The Iron Bard's Burden (Major, 8 XP)

Requirement: You have forgotten your own face in the mirror of your armor.

Your Defence is increased by 1, but you cannot regain Stress through social interaction until you unbuckle for a full scene. The isolation is complete; the protection is total.

7.3 The Regret That Remains (Prestige, 12 XP)

Requirement: You have survived a moment of connection that destroyed you, as Corin survived until he didn't.

CHAPTER 7. THE KNIGHT'S LEGACY: NEW TALENTS

You are a living witness to the disconnect. When you die, you may choose:

- Rise as a spirit of the threshold (guardian of a bridge or door, unable to leave but remembering all who pass), or
- Pass into the song (become a ballad, sung by Cantors, your name a lesson in mercy).

Chapter 8

The Joust and the Raid

8.1 The Setup

The party are knights, squires, or witnesses in a Vhasia at peace—but a peace of tightened screws. The tourney season is beginning. The raids have not stopped, merely become ritualised. The Ethorian marches are restive.

8.2 The Endings

- **The Armor Closes:** The party chooses protection over mercy. The cantons close. The wars begin.
- **The Song Escapes:** The party unbuckles, shows vulnerability, connects. They may be destroyed by it, or saved, but the moment is real.
- **The Cantor's Witness:** Alain sings their story. They become legend—cautionary or celebrated—but they become memory.

CHAPTER 8. THE JOUST AND THE RAID

Chapter 9

Appendix: The Chivalric Ledger

9.1 The Five Gestes of Vhasian Chivalry

1. The Geste of the Shield (protection offered).
2. The Geste of the Sword (challenge given).
3. The Geste of the Helm (courtesy shown).
4. The Geste of the Unbuckled Gorget (mercy offered).
5. The Geste of the Song (witness borne).

9.2 Ethorian Folklore

The barrow-kings demand tribute in stories, not gold. The sacred groves require bare feet. The *Barde de Fer* is sung at un-helming ceremonies, when a knight removes armor for the last time (in death or in retirement).

*This expansion was written in the Chapel of the Silent Stair, on
paper made from tourney programmes. The ink is lamp-black
and the oil of unbuckled armor. The binding is felt, to muffle
the bells.*

The armor is polished. The song is sung. The gorget is open.

— The Clerk of Rouen, in the year of the joust

Appendix B: The Fractured Crown – A Political Primer for the Cantons of Vhasia

A Note from the Raven Road

Set down by Scribe Valerius of the Thepyrgos Synod, at the request of the Raven Road. An addendum to “The Knave’s Regret,” with apologies for the lack of poetry.

A decade ago, Duke Braedon Fenwood of Viterra crossed the Belworth with fire and iron. His target was not the Vhasian people, but the Sun Court itself. He sacked Lence, scattered the royal family, and—most curiously—left the throne empty. “A crown that must be seized is not a crown,” he is said to have told his knights. “Let them fight over the pieces. It costs me less than a garrison.”

The result is a power vacuum that has turned Vhasia into a chessboard of claimants, condottieri, and cousins. Every duke, baron, and bastard with a drop of Sun blood now eyes the throne. Meanwhile, the common folk pay the tithes of three masters: the local lord, the claimant they hope will win, and the Vritann tax collector who never left.

This appendix provides tools for Game Masters to run the political chaos of Vhasia: faction clocks, claim mechanics, cross-border entanglements, and a parlement mini-game for those who prefer legal dagger-work to steel. It is designed to be used alongside *Blood on the Belworth* and the core *Political Intrigue* expansion.

The Vacant Throne Clock [10]

This campaign clock represents the race to fill the power vacuum in Lence. It ticks forward whenever:

- A claimant gains a significant advantage (a major battle, a noble defection, a foreign alliance).
- The party brokers a truce or exposes a claimant's weakness (ticks backward).
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats on off-screen political manoeuvring.

When the clock fills, a claimant (or a coalition) takes Lence and declares themselves king. The party's subsequent adventures will be shaped by whether they backed the winner, opposed them, or tried to stay neutral.

Claims as Strings and Assets

A **Claim** is a legal or blood right to a title, land, or influence. In Vhasia, a claim is also a weapon.

Claim Strings A minor claim (e.g., "third cousin of the last queen," "a debt of honour from a Fenwood raid") functions as a String. Once per session, the holder may invoke the claim to gain +1 die on a social roll involving a noble, a court, or a border dispute. The String is consumed after use.

Claim Assets A major claim (e.g., “the Sunburst Seal in my possession,” “the loyalty of the Ethorian Marches”) is a Minor or Standard Asset (4XP or 8XP). Its free off-screen effect might be: “Once per session, declare that a minor noble refuses a demand because your claim is superior.” Its Boon activation might allow you to force a duel of honour or call a moot.

The Sunburst Seal (Major Asset, 12XP) The physical seal of the old crown, lost in the sack of Lence. Whoever possesses it is considered the legitimate king by those who respect such symbols. Effects: free off-screen – “Your herald is granted audience at any court in Vhasia”; Boon activation – “You declare a law that stands until challenged by a higher authority (i.e., a claimant with more military force).” The Seal also draws envy; the GM may start a *Claimant’s Hunt* [6] clock when it is used.

Factions of the Fracture

po.22	po.22	po.22	po.22
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Faction	Goal	Clock	Strings / Leverage
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Faction	Goal	Clock	Strings / Leverage
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<i>The Sun-in-Exile</i>	Restore the rightful	Restoration [8] –	advances “The Queen’s Ring,” “A wet-nurse’s (surviving royal family) bloodline when they gain a military testimony,” “The lost register of births” backer or a border lord’s oath
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<i>The Fenwood Claim</i>	Install a Viterran puppet	Puppet’s Progress [6] – advances “Letters of safe-conduct from Viterra,” (Duke Braedon’s nephew, Touénot l’Argent) (or himself) when
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Touénot l'Argent wins a tourney, "The Belworth Bridge tolls," a Parlement vote, or a skirmish "A hostage oath from a border baron"

The Ducal Compact Maintain the vacuum Compact's Cohesion [6] – advances "A sealed apology," "A marriage contract,"

(three powerful dukes) while building their when they agree on a common "A map of shared salt-pans" own power enemy; retreats when they squabble

The Condotta Companies Get paid, or carve out Payday [8] – advances each "A captain's gambling debt,"

(mercenary captains) their own fief season they are not paid; when "A banner stolen from a rival," full, a company deserts or flips "A letter of marque from a phantom king"

The Armor Closes – A Chivalric Clock

This clock (size 6) tracks the emotional and psychological isolation of Vhasian knighthood. It advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The GM may also spend 2 SB to advance this clock when a character refuses to show vulnerability.

The companion clock, **The Song Escapes** (size 8), advances when Cantors sing the truth, when mercy is shown, when armor is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs – though it may be fatal.

The Belworth Border – Dual Loyalties and Claims

Many Vhasian lords hold lands on both sides of the Belworth, a legacy of the old united kingdom. This creates constant friction: **dual loyalties** and **overlapping claims**.

- **Dual Loyalty Clock** – A border baron who is also a Viterran count might have a clock [6]. When it advances, he leans toward his Viterran liege; when it retreats, toward his Vhasian claimant. Players can influence this clock by gifts, threats, or exposing secrets.
- **Fenwood's Shadow** – Duke Braedon Fenwood does not openly press a claim, but his agents are everywhere. A *Fenwood Intrigue* [8] clock ticks when the party crosses him. When full, a Fenwood assassin or a legal writ from Viterra arrives.
- **The Belworth Bridge** – This key crossing is a source of constant toll disputes. A *Bridge Toll* [4] clock ticks each time the party uses it without a proper pass. When full, the bridge is closed, forcing a dangerous ford or a long detour.

Touénot l'Argent (NPC) *"They call me Touched Not the Silver. The silver I refused at birth – the silver I will not take as a bribe – the silver that will buy my crown."*

The nephew of a distant Fenwood cousin, Touénot was raised in a Vhasian hedge-court, educated by a renegade Cantor, and knighted on a battlefield where he refused the customary silver price for his first prisoner. Now he styles himself the

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Heir by Abstention – the one man who never owed a Fenwood debt. x **Stats (Tier III):** Presence₄, Wits₃, Body₃, Spirit₃. Skills: Command₃, Sway₄, Melee₂, Lore₂ (Vhasian precedents).

Strings: “A silver thorn (his token),” “The testimony of a Lantern-Rite witness,” “A promise from the River Syndicate.”

Clock: *Touénot’s Coup* [6] – advances when he wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, he marches on Lence with a banner of silver and black.

Adventure Hook: Touénot offers the party a charter to collect the “Silver Tithe” – a tax on every crossing of the Belworth Bridge. The charter is legal, but the previous collector was found floating face-down, a silver coin in his mouth. The ghost now haunts the bridge, whispering: “*Touénot... l’Argent... the price...*”

The Parlement Mini-Game (Legal Duel)

When claimants cannot settle a dispute by steel, they turn to the Parlement of Lence – a rump assembly of clerics, lawyers, and surviving magistrates who still meet in a half-ruined hall. The party may be called as witnesses, advocates, or judges.

Procedure (3 beats):

1. **Precedent** – Each side presents a written citation (roll Wits+Lore, DV₄). Winner gains the “Precedent Edge” (+1 die in the final ruling).
2. **Witness** – Each side calls a witness (real or bribed). The GM sets a social DV (3-5) based on the witness’s loyalty. Winner gains “Witness Favour” (can force a re-roll on one die in the final ruling).

3. **Judgment** – The presiding magistrate (or the party, if they have the authority) declares a verdict. The player designated as judge rolls Spirit+Command (DV₅). Success means their preferred outcome holds; failure means the magistrate rules against them, or the losing side rejects the verdict and the dispute escalates to combat.

Outcomes: A legal victory grants a Claim String on the defeated party, and may advance or retreat a faction clock.

New Talents for Vhasian Knights and Courtiers

Claimant's Voice (Minor, 4XP) You have trained in the art of the Parlement. Once per session, when you invoke a Claim String, you may also force a single NPC to make a Resolve test (DV₄) or reveal their true allegiance in that matter.

Banner of the Empty Throne (Major, 8XP) You carry a standard that claims to represent the true king (even if you do not know who that is). Once per session, you may declare a safe-conduct for yourself and your allies in any Vhasian canton. The safe-conduct is honoured until you are exposed as a fraud (GM discretion) or a rival claimant denounces you.

The Unbuckled Gorget (Minor, 4XP) *Requirement: You have shown mercy while vulnerable.* Once per session you may declare that you remove a piece of armor (helm, gauntlet, or gorget) to show trust. Gain +1 die to social rolls with honourable enemies, but suffer +1 Harm from the next attack against you.

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The Iron Bard's Burden (Major, 8XP) *Requirement: You have forgotten your own face in the mirror of your armor.* Your Defence is increased by 1, but you cannot regain Stress through social interaction until you unbuckle for a full scene. The isolation is complete; the protection is total.

The Unbuckled Gorge (Prestige, 10XP, requires *Unbuckled Gorget*) When you remove a piece of armour to show vulnerability, you also gain the ability to speak one true sentence that cannot be interrupted. The sentence must be a single clause, and it is heard by all present as if you had whispered it in their ear. Afterward, you mark 1 Corruption (the weight of unarmoured truth). *"I was afraid."* — Ser Roran.

Sample Claimant: Touénot l'Argent du Istovar (NPC)

The nephew of Duke Braedon, Touénot l'Argent was raised in Vhasia as a hostage and now styles himself the "Heir by Deliverance." He is handsome, charismatic, and utterly ruthless – a mirror of Richard III before the fall.

Stats (Tier III): Presence₄, Wits₃, Body₃, Spirit₂. Skills: Command₃, Sway₃, Melee₂, Deception₃.

Strings: "A promise from the Ethor Duke," "A letter of safe-conduct from Viterra," "The captain of the Lence garrison (bribed)."

Clock: *Touénot l'Argent's Coup* [6] – advances when he wins a Parlement session, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, he marches on Lence. The party may accelerate or decelerate this clock.

Adventure Hook: Touénot l'Argent offers the party a charter to collect tolls on the Belworth Bridge in exchange for their support. The charter is genuine – but the previous toll-collector was murdered, and his ghost now haunts the bridge, demanding to know who betrayed him.

Blood on the Belworth – A Campaign Frame

The adventure *Blood on the Belworth* (from the *Political Intrigue* expansion) is designed to run in this exact period. Its core mechanics – Situation Clocks, Counter-Clocks, Faction Sheets, and the Hedge-Law Moot – fit seamlessly with the Vhasian setting.

GMs are encouraged to:

- Use the *Armor Closes* clock as a backdrop to the knight-hood scenes.
- Allow the *Unbuckled Gorget* talent to grant a bonus in the hedge-law scenes (showing vulnerability before the Lantern-Rites).
- Introduce the *Sunburst Seal* as a potential prize for resolving the ferry murders.
- Let players who invoke a *Claim String* automatically know one of the clue threads in Act II.

The Round of Five Virtues

In Bretonian tourneys, victory is not decided by blood alone. A panel of nobles, heralds, and a chosen *Lady of Honour* judges

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each passage of arms by five knightly virtues. A combatant may be unhorsed yet praised; another may strike true yet be disgraced.

The Five Virtues

Each exchange is scored from 0 to 2 in five categories:

Courage – Facing danger without recklessness, standing firm when pressed.

Courtesy – Respect toward opponent, the crowd, and the Lady of Honour.

Mercy – Sparing the fallen, offering aid, refusing to strike a helpless foe.

Prowess – Skill with lance, sword, or axe; horsemanship; tactical acumen.

Truth – Fighting under one's true banner, keeping sworn oaths, honesty in the lists.

The Judging Panel

- **Lady of Honour** – presides, offers a favour (scarf, sleeve, or ring) to a chosen competitor. Her word breaks ties.
- **Herald of the Lists** – records blows, enforces rules, announces scores.
- **Two Knight- Adjudicators** – one chosen by each competing house or party.
- **(Optional) Cleric or Druid** – for tourneys blessed by the Old Faith or the Church.

Scoring Rounds

A formal tourney is fought in three passes (joust) or three bouts (melee). Between rounds the judges confer openly. Use the scorecard below.

Virtue	o Points	
Courage	Fleeing, cowardice, refusing combat	Hold
Courtesy	Insults, ignoring the Lady, foul language	Prop
Mercy	Striking a fallen foe, refusing quarter	Acceptin
Prowess	Missed strikes, broken lance, unhorsed early	Clean hit
Truth	False colours, broken oath, concealed weapon	Fighting und

Table 9.1: Bretonian Tourney Scorecard – The Five Virtues

Special Rules

The Lady's Favour Before the tourney, each competitor may request a favour from a noble lady (not necessarily the Lady of Honour). A favour grants +1 die to one Prowess roll but imposes -1 Position on any Courtesy roll (the crowd watches closely). Favours are physical tokens (sleeve, ribbon, ring) that can be displayed or returned.

The Pledge of Truth All combatants must swear the *Pledge of Truth* before the assembled court. Breaking the pledge (e.g., fighting under false colours) immediately loses 2 Virtue points in Truth and may disqualify the offender. The oath is:

“By my spurs, by my liege, and by the light of this Lady’s eyes, I swear I bear no false heraldry, no poison, and no enchantment save that which a knight

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may honourably carry. May my horse falter if I lie; may my sword turn in my hand if I deceive.”

The Judgment of the Twelve For disputes that cannot be settled by the panel, any knight may demand the *Judgment of the Twelve* – six champions a side, fighting a mounted melee until one party yields or the Lady of Honour declares the truth revealed. The Judgment ignores normal scoring; the outcome is accepted as divine witness.

Honour Shame Tokens Competitors earn **Honour Tokens** for acts of mercy, courtesy, or truth (spend to improve Position once). They earn **Shame Tokens** for cowardice, cruelty, or lies (GM may spend to worsen Position). Three Shame Tokens in a single tourney lead to public disgrace – the knight is stripped of spurs and cannot compete again without a pilgrimage.

Sample Scorecard (Joust – Three Rounds)

Use this table at the table.

Round	Sir Alaric	Sir Renaud	Notes
Courage (1st pass)	1	2	Renaud charges into broken lance
Courtesy (1st pass)	2	1	Alaric salutes the Lady, Renaud mutters
Mercy (1st pass)	2	2	Both pull up to avoid trampling a horse
Prowess (1st pass)	1	2	Renaud unhorses Alaric
Truth (1st pass)	2	2	Both banners true
Courage (2nd pass)	2	1	Alaric remounts under fire
...	...	...	...
TOTAL	14	12	Alaric wins by Virtue

Integration with Fate's Edge

- Use the **Seven Bell Court** mechanics for any generic formal duel (Form, Spirit, Intent). Use **Round of Five Virtues** for Arthurian / Bretonian / crusader settings.
- Clocks such as *Crowd Mood*, *Tournament Integrity*, and *Lady's Patience* work unchanged.
- The Lady of Honour may be a PC with appropriate social talents (e.g., *Courtly Graces*, *Silver Tongue*).

GM Guidance

Bretonian tourneys are as much about reputation as about victory. Encourage players to narrate their shields, their favours, and their vows. Use the Virtues to reward roleplay – a knight who dismounts to help a fallen foe should gain Mercy points even if he loses the match.

A simple mantra: *“The lance is judged, but the heart is weighed.”*

Closing Notes from the Raven Road

The crown is a story we tell ourselves to make the violence bearable. The claimants tell competing versions. The people listen and pay their tithes. And the Fenwood duke sits across the river, sharpening his quill.

Do not mistake the vacuum for peace. It is only the pause between breaths.

— Dusana of the Raven Road

On the Belworth ferry, waiting for the fog to lift